

FROM REQUIREMENT TO BACKLOG · STEP BY STEP

Personal Banking Management System

Turning four requirement areas into Epics, User Stories and Use Cases

1

Read the requirement

actors, scope, a North Star

2

Carve Epics

outcome-sized containers

3

Split into Stories

sprint-sized, testable

4

Promote to Use Cases

only where flows get complex

One worked example carried through every step: sending money to a friend

What we were given — and what is missing

Twelve features in four groups. Before writing a single epic, name the actors, the boundary and the outcome



Account Management

- Multiple account types
- Real-time balance tracking
- Account statements



Transaction Services

- Fund transfers
- Bill payments
- Transaction history



Financial Analytics

- Spending insights
- Budget management
- Financial goals tracking



Security & Support

- Multi-factor authentication
- Customer support
- Notification system

ACTORS WE CAN SEE (AND ONE WE CAN'T)

Anita, 29 — salaried retail customer, pays rent & bills monthly, sends money to family, checks balance daily on her phone

Support agent — resolves failed payments and disputes, needs the customer's context

Core banking / payment rails (UPI, NEFT, biller) — external systems the platform depends on

Missing from the brief: who onboards the customer? who monitors fraud? — ask, or make an explicit assumption

READING BETWEEN THE LINES

Outcome (our North Star): customers do their everyday banking in the app without calling the branch — monthly active users completing ≥ 1 transaction.

Boundary: the app and its APIs; core banking, KYC and payment rails are outside.

Hidden requirements: onboarding/KYC before any account exists; RBI 2FA rules for payments; limits & cut-off times; audit trail.



Rule of thumb A feature list is not a requirement. Rewrite each group as 'who needs what, why' before slicing — the 'why' is what tells you where the epic boundaries are.

Requirement groups are not epics — regroup by user goal

An epic is a large body of work that delivers one user outcome, spans several sprints, and can be split into independently valuable stories

12 FEATURES AS GIVEN

- Multiple account types
- Real-time balance tracking
- Account statements
- Fund transfers
- Bill payments
- Transaction history
- Spending insights
- Budget management
- Financial goals tracking
- Multi-factor authentication
- Customer support
- Notification system

5 EPICS, EACH NAMED AS A USER GOAL

E1 · Secure onboarding & access

Anita can enrol, log in and approve payments safely (MFA, device binding, session rules)

E2 · Accounts at a glance

Anita sees every account, balance and statement in one place, always current

E3 · Move money

Anita sends money and pays bills in under a minute, with certainty it went through

E4 · Understand & plan my money

Anita understands where her money goes and stays on track to her goals

E5 · Help & stay informed

Anita gets answers and alerts without calling the branch

HOW WE DECIDED THE CUTS

MFA moved out of 'Security & Support' — it is a prerequisite for everything, so it is the first epic, not a support feature.

Transaction history joined Accounts — Anita reads history to check her balance story, not to move money.

Support + notifications became one epic — both answer 'what is happening with my money?' proactively or on demand.

Test for a good epic: name it as a goal ('Move money', not 'Transactions module'); it has one owner and one KPI; it can ship value after its first two stories.



Rule of thumb If an epic name contains the word 'module', 'management' or 'services', it is a system component, not a user goal. Rename it until a customer would recognise it.

Each epic on one line — hypothesis, measure, size

Write the epic as a hypothesis so the team knows what ‘done’ proves, not just what it contains

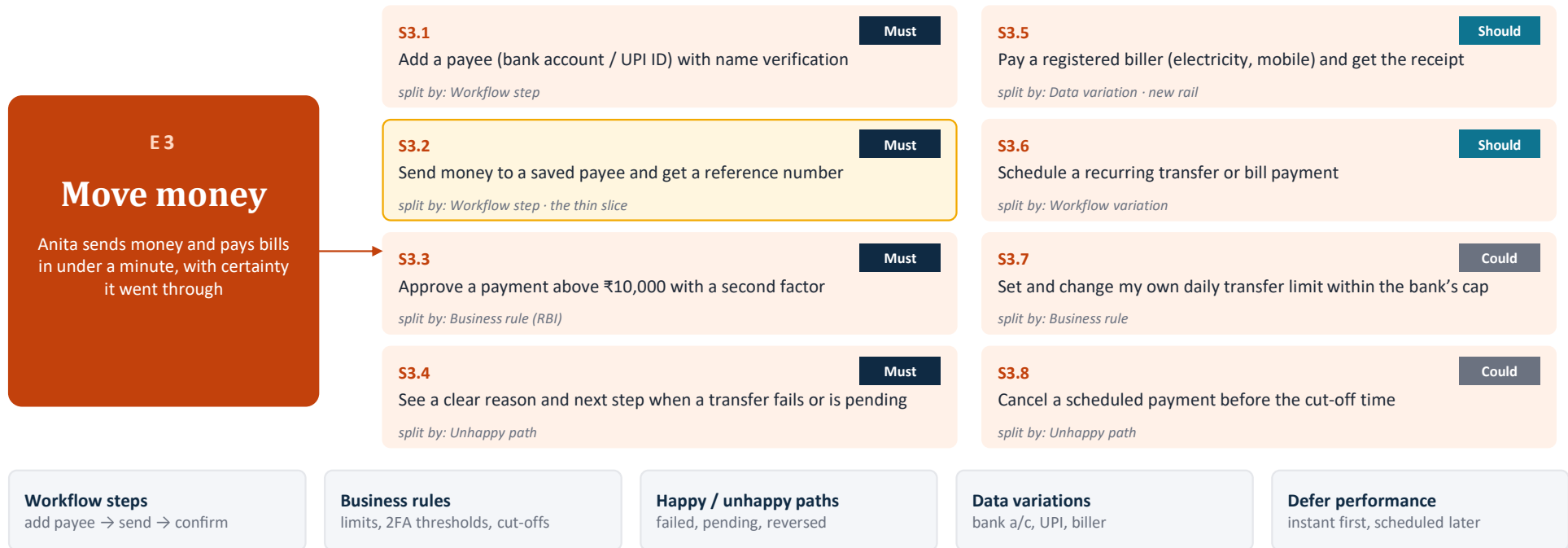
Epic	Hypothesis (we believe ... will ... we'll know when ...)	Primary persona	Success metric	Features covered	Size
E1 · Secure onboarding & access	We believe secure, low-friction login and payment approval will make customers trust the app for real money; we'll know when > 90% of payments are approved in-app without a support call.	Anita · Support agent	MFA success rate · account-takeover incidents = 0	Multi-factor authentication (+ onboarding, device binding)	L · 4–6 sprints
E2 · Accounts at a glance	We believe one always-current view of all accounts will replace branch/ATM balance checks; we'll know when daily balance views per user rise and balance-enquiry calls fall.	Anita	Daily active balance views · statement downloads	Multiple account types · real-time balance · statements · transaction history	M · 3–4 sprints
E3 · Move money	We believe sub-minute, certain transfers and bill payments will move everyday payments into the app; we'll know when ≥ 60% of eligible bill payments happen in-app.	Anita	Payment success rate · time to complete · failed-payment tickets	Fund transfers · bill payments	L · 5–7 sprints
E4 · Understand & plan my money	We believe seeing spending by category and progress to goals will increase engagement and savings balances; we'll know when budget users log in 2x more.	Anita	% users with an active budget · goal completion	Spending insights · budget · goals	M · 3–5 sprints
E5 · Help & stay informed	We believe proactive alerts and in-app help will cut support cost per customer; we'll know when contact rate per 1,000 users falls 30%.	Anita · Support agent	Contact rate · first-contact resolution	Notifications · customer support	M · 3–4 sprints



Rule of thumb Sequence epics by dependency and learning, not by requirement order: E1 unblocks everything; E3 carries the most risk and value, so its first stories should land early.

Worked example: E3 “Move money” → eight stories

Split along the seams users feel — workflow steps, business rules, unhappy paths, data variations — never along technical layers



Rule of thumb S3.2 (highlighted) is the thin end-to-end slice: one payee, one rail, no limits logic. If it ships alone, a real customer can already send money. Everything else extends it.

S3.2 in full — card, conversation, confirmation

A story is a card (the sentence), a conversation (details agreed with the team) and a confirmation (acceptance criteria that become tests)

S3.2 · SEND MONEY TO A SAVED PAYEE

As a **retail customer (Anita)**

I want to

send money to a payee I have already saved, from any of my accounts,
so that

I can pay family and friends in under a minute and know for certain it went through.

ACCEPTANCE CRITERIA (Given / When / Then)

AC1 Given a saved payee and sufficient balance, when Anita enters an amount $\leq$ her daily limit and confirms, then the debit is posted, a reference number is shown within 5 s, and the payee appears in transaction history.

AC2 Given insufficient balance, when she confirms, then no debit happens and the message names the shortfall and offers to change the source account.

AC3 Given the payment rail times out, when no response arrives in 30 s, then the transfer is shown as 'Pending', no duplicate is created on retry, and she is notified of the final status.

AC4 Given any outcome, then an audit event (who, what, when, from which device) is recorded.

INVEST CHECK



Independent

needs S3.1 only; not the rails for bills



Negotiable

UI, confirmation style open to the team



Valuable

a real payment, end to end



Estimable

team sized it at 5 points



Small

fits one sprint



Testable

4 ACs → 4 automated tests

SAME NEED, WRITTEN BADLY

"As a user I want a fund transfer screen so that I can transfer funds."

X 'user' — which one? behaviour differs for Anita vs a support agent

X 'screen' — prescribes the solution, not the need

X 'so that I can transfer funds' — restates the want; no benefit, so no way to prioritise

X no acceptance criteria — 'done' is whatever the developer decides



Rule of thumb If you cannot write the 'so that' without repeating the 'I want', you have not found the need yet — go back to the persona.

Two to three stories per epic is enough to start — the rest emerge

Prioritised with MoSCoW; the 'Must' column across all five epics is release 1

Epic	ID	User story (card only)	Persona	Priority	Notes / dependency
E1	S1.1	As Anita, I want to register with my mobile number and verify with OTP and video KYC so that I can start using the app without visiting a branch.	Anita	Must	KYC vendor API
E1	S1.2	As Anita, I want to log in with biometrics on a bound device so that daily access is fast but still safe.	Anita	Must	Device binding first
E1	S1.3	As Anita, I want a second factor before any payment above ₹10,000 so that a stolen phone can't empty my account.	Anita	Must	Used by S3.3
E2	S2.1	As Anita, I want to see all my accounts with live balances on one screen so that I know what I can spend right now.	Anita	Must	Core banking balance API
E2	S2.2	As Anita, I want to search and filter my transactions so that I can find a payment when I dispute it.	Anita	Should	Feeds support S5.2
E2	S2.3	As Anita, I want to download a monthly statement as PDF so that I can share it for a loan or visa.	Anita	Should	—
E3	S3.1–S3.4	Add payee · send to saved payee · 2FA above limit · clear failure states (see previous slide)	Anita	Must	S1.3, rails
E3	S3.5	As Anita, I want to pay a registered biller and get a receipt so that I never miss a due date.	Anita	Should	Biller aggregator
E4	S4.1	As Anita, I want my spending auto-categorised by month so that I can see where the money went without effort.	Anita	Should	Needs 3 months history
E4	S4.2	As Anita, I want to set a monthly budget per category and be warned at 80% so that I stop before overspending.	Anita	Could	Uses S5.1 alerts
E5	S5.1	As Anita, I want an instant alert for every debit so that I spot fraud within minutes.	Anita	Must	Push + SMS
E5	S5.2	As a support agent, I want to see the customer's recent transactions and alerts when they call so that I can resolve a failed payment in one contact.	Agent	Should	Consent & masking



Rule of thumb Release 1 = the 'Must' rows: register, log in, see balances, send money safely, get alerts. That is a usable bank in five epics' worth of thin slices — analytics and support depth come after real usage data.

UC-03 “Transfer funds to a saved payee” in full

Write a use case only where the story hides many paths, multiple actors or regulatory rules — here, all three

UC-03 · Transfer funds to a saved payee

Primary actor: Retail customer (Anita) **Supporting actors:** Core banking, payment rail (UPI/NEFT), OTP service, notification service

Stakeholders: Bank compliance (RBI 2FA & limits), fraud team (audit trail)

Preconditions: customer authenticated; payee saved & verified; source account active

Trigger: customer selects a payee and taps ‘Send’

Postconditions (success): debit posted, credit instructed, reference issued, history & audit updated, alert sent

Postconditions (failure): no debit or a reversed debit; customer knows the state and next step

Traces to: E3 · S3.2, S3.3, S3.4 · ACs 1–4 · tests TC-31...TC-38

MAIN SUCCESS SCENARIO

1. Customer selects payee, source account, enters amount and optional note
2. System validates amount against balance, per-transaction and daily limits
3. If amount > ₹10,000, system requests second factor; customer approves (S3.3)
4. System places a hold, sends instruction to the payment rail, records ‘Processing’
5. Rail confirms; system posts debit, issues reference number, updates history
6. System sends debit alert and shows confirmation with reference (< 5 s end-to-end)

EXTENSIONS (ALTERNATE & EXCEPTION FLOWS)

2a Insufficient balance → show shortfall, offer another source account; end.

2b Daily limit exceeded → show remaining limit and reset time; offer to schedule for tomorrow (S3.6).

3a Second factor fails 3× → lock payments for 30 min, notify customer, log security event.

5a Rail times out → status ‘Pending’; retry with same idempotency key; reverse hold if rail rejects; notify final state.

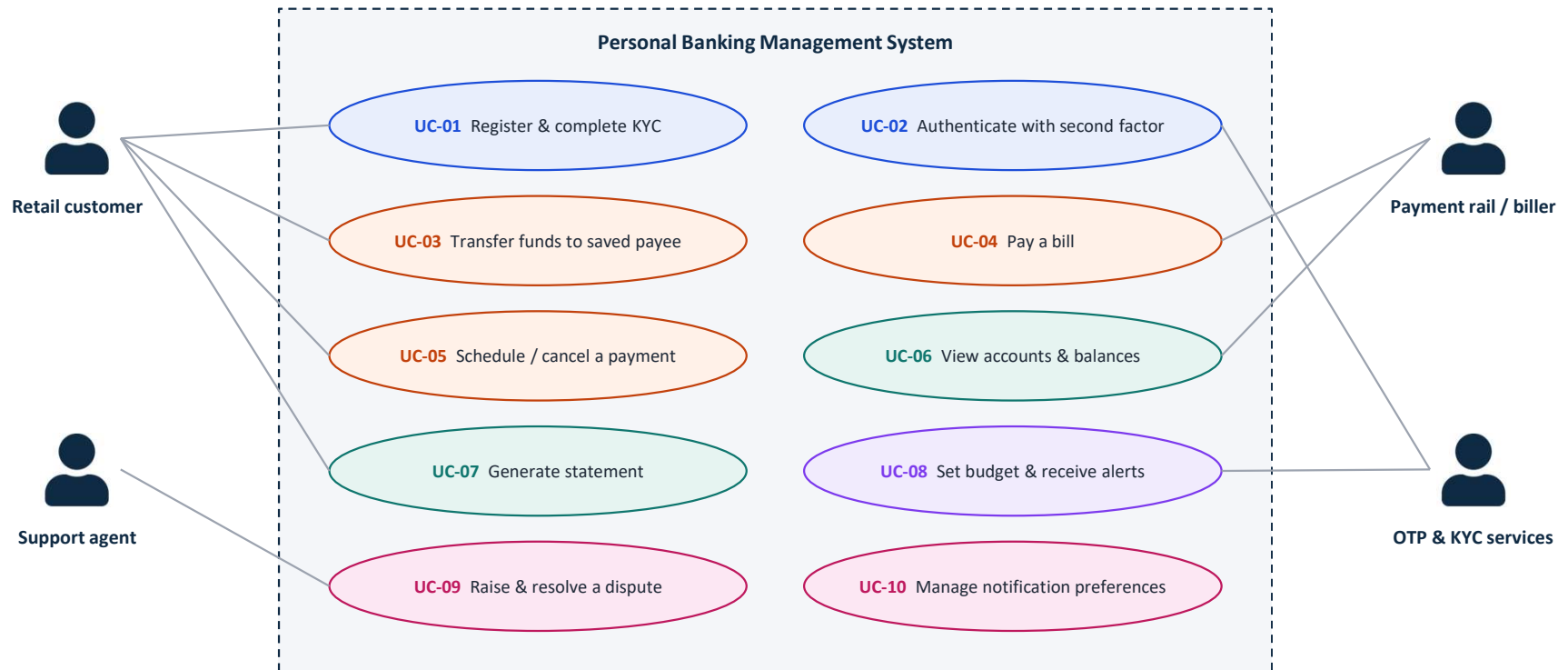
5b Rail rejects (invalid account) → release hold, mark payee ‘needs re-verification’, explain in plain language.



Rule of thumb Every extension row becomes a test case and usually a story (5a is S3.4). If the extensions section is empty, either the flow is trivial — don’t write the use case — or you haven’t thought hard enough.

Which stories earned a use case — and which did not

Ten use cases cover the flows with real branching; simple CRUD-style stories stay as stories with acceptance criteria



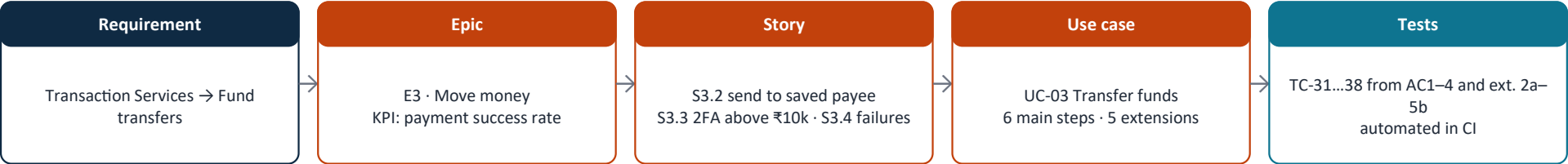
Ovals coloured by epic · only a sample of associations drawn for legibility



Rule of thumb Stories that stayed stories: 'search transactions', 'download PDF', 'auto-categorise spending'. One actor, one path, no rules — acceptance criteria are enough.

Traceability: one line from the brief to a test

Follow the ‘send money’ example through every artefact — this is how you prove coverage and find orphans



Requirement group	Epic(s)	Stories	Use cases	Gap / orphan check
Account Management	E2	S2.1 – S2.3	UC-06, UC-07	✓ covered · ‘multiple account types’ needs a story per type (savings, current, FD)
Transaction Services	E3 (+E2 history)	S3.1 – S3.8	UC-03, UC-04, UC-05	✓ covered · limits & cut-offs were not in the brief — added as rules
Financial Analytics	E4	S4.1, S4.2 (+goals TBD)	UC-08	⚠ ‘financial goals tracking’ has no story yet — backlog item
Security & Support	E1, E5	S1.1 – S1.3, S5.1, S5.2	UC-01, UC-02, UC-09, UC-10	✓ covered · fraud monitoring is an orphan — no requirement, but a real need



Before you call the backlog ready

Every feature in the brief maps to at least one story · every epic has a KPI and a named persona · every ‘Must’ story has Given/When/Then criteria · every use case names its extensions and traces to stories · at least one internal-user story exists · you have written down what you assumed because the brief did not say

YOUR TURN

Repeat the four steps on the two epics we did not expand

E4 'Understand & plan my money' and E5 'Help & stay informed' — 30 minutes, then present one story and one use case

1

Read

Write E4 and E5 as hypotheses with a KPI. Name the persona for each — is it always Anita?

5 min

2

Split

Produce 5–6 stories per epic using the five splitting seams. Tag each with MoSCoW. Mark the thin slice.

10 min

3

Write

Take one 'Must' story and write it fully: card, 3–4 Given/When/Then criteria, INVEST check.

8 min

4

Promote

Decide which ONE story in each epic deserves a use case, and write its main flow plus at least three extensions.

7 min



WHAT A STRONG ANSWER LOOKS LIKE

- Epics named as goals, not modules
- A 'so that' that a customer would actually say
- Unhappy paths inside the acceptance criteria
- A use case only where flows branch — and it says why
- One assumption written down that the brief left open



Remember This deck is one model answer. Different cuts of the same requirement are equally valid if every epic has an outcome, every story has a benefit, and every use case earns its length.